

Stephen Wheeler

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Career Summary

UX Researcher with three decades of professional experience delivering outstanding user experiences at leading Silicon Valley tech companies for a broad variety of product domains, thriving in environments with large user populations. Comprehensive UXR practice from foundational to directional, with an emphasis on delivering insights from research at scale and quantitative UXR methodologies. Strong affinity for skills sharing and mentorship.

Professional Experience

Sabbatical/career break

November 2023 – present

- **Skills development, personal projects:** top contributor in Reddit forums as r/gsheets145.
- **Volunteering:** UXR for non-profits; tutoring Zürich-based Gymnasium students in IT and English.
- **Travel and personal development:** I organised a 40th anniversary school reunion, locating 70% of classmates.

Principal UX Researcher, Roche (Basel, Switzerland)

July 2023 – November 2023

- **Floodlight MS:** Successfully advocated for UXR in the gamification of an app for people with MS. Led two UXR concept evaluations, identifying key design principles via insights from MS patients.

Senior UX Researcher, Google/YouTube (SF Bay Area; Zürich, Switzerland)

May 2012 – May 2023

- **Horizontal Insights:** Developed and maintained the cross-functional Product Excellence dashboard.
- **Modernisation:** Identified principles for writing clarity for cross-product UI text via a survey evaluation; developed survey and data-analysis templates for later iterations.
- **Shopping:** Shaped foundational product design & strategy via multiple studies with viewers and creators.
- **Creator Studio:** Enabled successful migration from Classic Studio by identifying fundamental insights for design and IA improvements via a series of mixed-methods UXR studies.
- **Rapid Research:** Developed and deployed rapid, remote, at-scale methods to support research needs of multiple teams horizontally across YouTube; mentored a team of junior researchers.
- **Main App:** Generated key IA and UX insights advocating for the successful transition to the current 'bottom nav'.
- **Survey Researcher:** Established longitudinal product satisfaction as a key metric via longitudinal Happiness Tracking Surveys (HaTS). Invented Flowtrics, a method for rapid, survey-mediated, at-scale design evaluation.
- **Geo:** My series of 'guerrilla' studies led to the redesign of Google My Maps.

Previous UX Research experience (Boston, NYC, SF Bay Area)

1994–2012

- **Oracle** (2011–12): Senior UX researcher for various Middleware applications.
- **Zynga** (2009–10): Led multiple studies for popular social games; implemented in-game satisfaction surveys.
- **Self-employed UXR consultant** (2008–11): Led in-person, remote, and at-scale UX studies for clients including Intuit, ING, VMWare, Glassdoor, AnswerLab, Splunk, World Bank.
- **Yahoo!** (2003–08): Led UX studies broadly across Yahoo! properties, focusing on premium services for strategic partnerships with broadband providers (AT&T, Rogers).
- **Microsoft WebTV** (1998–2002): Led studies for Microsoft's emerging interactive TV products.
- **Netscape** (1997–98): Usability studies, field studies, surveys for SuiteSpot server products.
- **Logica Inc.** (1994–96): Usability for Interactive TV (various Telcos); trading systems (Reuters).

Other relevant experience (London, UK)

1987–1994

- **Logica** (1992–94): Software development and systems integration for multiple clients.
- **J.P.Morgan** (1989–90): Analyst/Programmer, database developer for back-office and trading systems.
- **County NatWest** (1987–89): Analyst/Programmer for back-office and trading systems.

Methodological and technical skills

Comprehensive expertise in quantitative/at-scale UXR methods:

- Survey design, implementation, and analysis (Qualtrics, Confront)
- Benchmarking
- At-scale prototype testing
- A/B and multivariate experiments
- Statistical methods and analysis
- Card sorting, tree testing
- Longitudinal tracking of user behaviour and attitudes
- Data visualisation, dashboards, storytelling

Comprehensive expertise in industry-standard qualitative UXR methods:

- Ethnographic methods (field studies, contextual interviews)
- In-lab/remote usability testing (concept evaluations, RITE testing, etc.)
- Insights reporting and presentation

Other relevant expertise:

- Multiple programming languages (HTML/CSS/Javascript/jQuery, Python, PHP, C, C++, Cobol, SQL)
- Google Workspace, MS Office, etc.

Education

- **University of London** (1991-92) M.Sc. Human Factors in Human-Computer Interaction: Pass with Distinction.
- **Christ Church, University of Oxford** (1982-85) Smith Exhibitioner; MA Zoology 2:1; Gibbs Field Studies Prize.

Personal details

- UK/US/EU citizenship
- Switzerland B permit (valid until November 2028)

Language skills

- English: Native speaker
- German: basic
- French: basic

Activities and interests

- Keen tennis player, active member of TC Riesbach (Vorstand member 2023); Interclub player; winner of 2024 Stadt Zürich R6-R9 Tennismeisterschaft.
- I actively enjoy running, hiking, skiing, mountain biking, road cycling; I have completed four marathons, the 2021 Ride Across Britain, and four Étapes du Tour (de France).
- I enjoy word games, puzzles, music, guitar, and developing applications for fun.